

GMZ Landscaping Inc.

DESIGN · BUILD · MAINTENANCE

How the work actually runs.

Standard operating procedures and workflow diagrams for both service lines, from the first call to the follow-up, with the board agenda for signing them off.

An SOP is not a description of what happens. It is what happens, written down so it happens the same way when the person who normally does it is on a roof in Woodside. Every procedure here names who owns it, what starts it, what it produces, and the one thing that must not be skipped. Where a step exists because of a law or because GMZ lost money learning it, that reason is stated, because a rule without its reason is the first rule to get dropped.

INTERNAL · NOT FOR CLIENT DISTRIBUTION

COVERS

21 procedures, 6 workflow diagrams,
both service lines

DATED

17 August 2026
Supersedes nothing; this is the first
issue

COMPANION

Lead-to-sale pipeline and pricing
explains why the money is shaped this
way. This document says what to do.

01 BEFORE ANYTHING ELSE

Who may do what, and what this document is not

Most of what goes wrong in a small contracting business is not a skill problem. It is somebody doing a thing they were not the right person to do, or doing it from memory when it should have been read off a page.

Authority: the four things that need the right person

THIS	WHO MAY DO IT	WHY IT IS FENCED
Quote a price to a client, in any form, including out loud on site	Owner or office admin only	A number said aloud is a number GMZ will be held to, and it has to clear the minimum first. That check is not a field task.
Take payment or a deposit	Owner or office admin only	Deposits are capped by statute and payments are tied to completed phases. Collecting out of sequence creates a problem no invoice fixes later.
Attend a property alone on GMZ business	Administrative roles only	A solo visit involves quoting, judgement and representing the company. Those are management responsibilities and are not part of a laborer role.
Drive a GMZ vehicle	Named drivers on the auto policy only	An unlisted driver is a coverage question nobody wants answered after the fact. The current named list lives in the facts sheet, not here, because it changes.

What this document is

- The procedure, in order, for anyone doing the step.
- The gates: what must be true before the next step runs.
- The named exceptions, so nobody has to invent one.
- Client-facing fees, because those are published.

What it deliberately is not

- **Not a price book.** Minimums, rates and the build-up behind them live in the facts sheet and are read from there every time. Copying one here would create a second home for a number that changes.
- **Not a staff list.** Roles, not names, so a departure does not invalidate a procedure.
- **Not policy.** Anything undecided is marked pending, not written as settled.

What is in here

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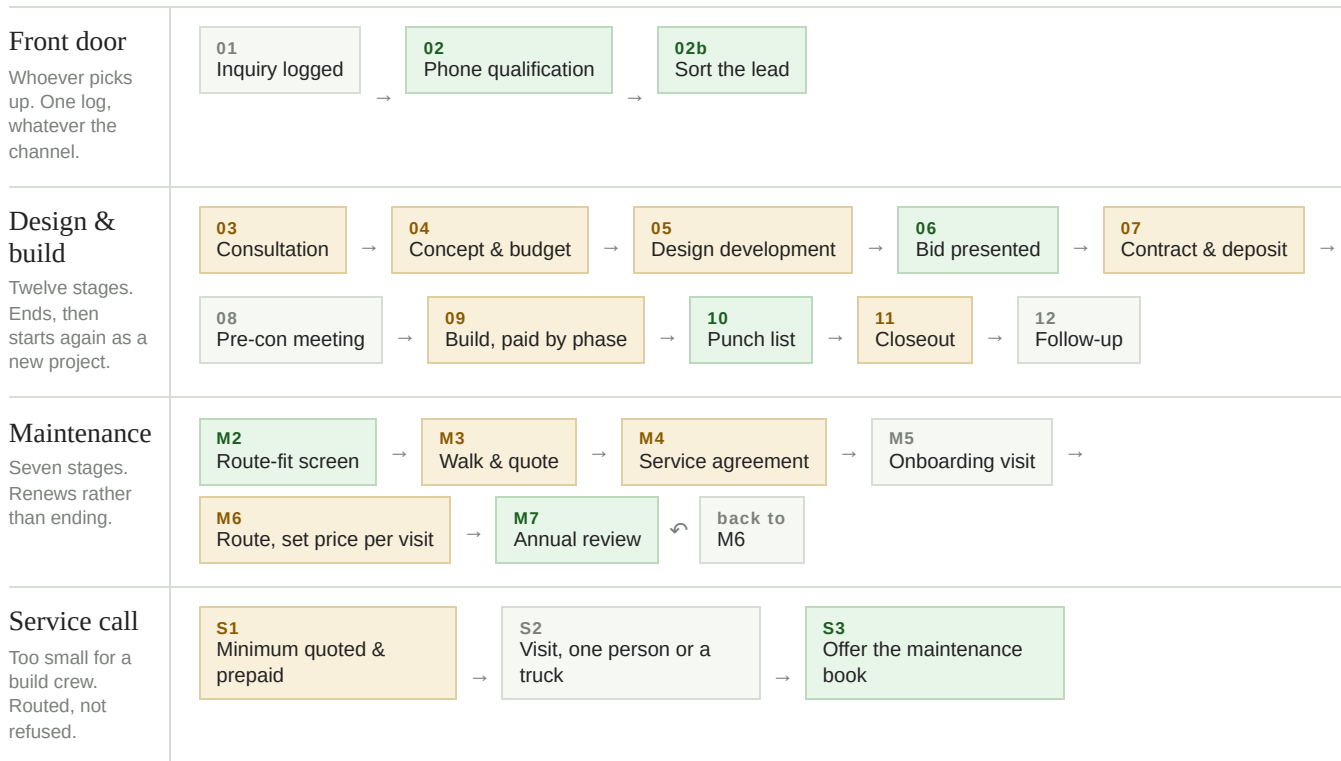
Reading the diagrams

-  Step runs, nothing charged
  Client pays at this step
  Gate: a decision is asked for and can be a no

02 DIAGRAM 1

Two service lines, one front door

Every lead arrives at the same place and is sorted once, on the first call. After that the two lines never merge: separate agreements, separate pricing, separate calendars.



Where the two lines touch

Only twice, and both are handoffs rather than merges. A finished build is offered the maintenance book at closeout, as an offer and not a condition. An existing maintenance client wanting a project runs the full design and build pipeline, with the consultation fee waived because the crew is already on the property.

Where a lead can leave

Four places, all of them cheap: declined on the call, declined after the consultation by either side, stopped after the concept phase, or not signing the bid. Nothing before the design agreement and the construction contract obligates a client to continue, and saying so plainly is what makes the paid steps easy to sell.

What is different from how this ran before

STAGE	BEFORE	NOW
Inquiry	Three inboxes, nothing shared	One log, on arrival, whoever takes it
Qualification	None. The visit was the first filter	Fifteen minutes on the phone, budget band asked
Consultation	Free and unstructured	Paid, prepaid, run off a checklist
Concept and budget	Given away	A paid first phase of the design agreement
Contract	Varied by job, sometimes an accepted estimate	One compliant template, every job above the threshold
Completion	Varied by job	Written punch list, ten business days, every job
After	Nothing	Closeout package, then calls at thirty days and six months

03 DIAGRAM 2

Sorting the lead, in order, on the first call

Work down the questions. The first one that decides it, decides it. Getting this wrong sends a build crew to do an hour of work, or prices an hour of work like a project.

1. Is the property inside the towns GMZ works in?

Yes	Carry on to question 2. No travel charge.
Near the list	Carry on, and add the travel charge to whatever visit is booked. Say the number on this call.
Past the outer limit	Decline now. Give the reason. Do not book a visit you will regret driving to.

2. Does the client already have a complete plan set from an architect or designer?

Yes, complete	Design and build, no design fee . Skips stages 04 and 05. Ask for the plan, the plant list and any grading, drainage and construction details, and check the drawings against the ground before pricing.
Partial, or a sketch	Treat as no. The paid design step still has to happen.

3. What kind of work is it, in the client's own words?

A project	Suits a build crew: planting, irrigation, drainage, patio, wall, fence, lighting. Go to question 4.
Ongoing upkeep	Maintenance. Run the route-fit screen before quoting or driving (SOP M2). Openings are specific days, not any day.
One thing fixed or tidied	Service call (SOP S1). An afternoon of pruning, a repair, a small refresh, a one-time cleanup. Quote the minimum and take it before booking.
They do not know	Ask what the problem is, not what should be built: standing water, dead lawn, no privacy, unusable slope, nowhere to sit. The answer sorts it.

4. Are the described scope and the stated budget band in the same neighbourhood?

Yes	Book the consultation. Quote the fee and take it now , on this call, before the date goes in the calendar.
No	Say so on the call. It is the kindest version of the conversation and it is far cheaper than the same conversation after a design is underway.
They will not say	Information in itself. Record it as refused. At small scopes, genuinely not knowing is fine and not a reason to decline.

04 DIAGRAM 3

When money arrives, and what it is for

Every charge answers a client asking “what am I paying for?” If a step cannot answer that in one sentence, it should not be charged for.

First call	Fifteen minutes on scope, band, timeline, decision makers, location.	Nothing
Booking the visit	Taken before the date is confirmed, and before anybody drives. Prepaid deliberately: a fee agreed at the property is a contract signed away from our place of business, which carries a statutory cancellation right and, without the right notice attached, one that never expires.	Consultation fee + travel if out of area
Concept phase	First phase of the design agreement. Buys a written concept and a planning range, on paper, from somebody who stood on the site.	Concept phase fee
Design development	Second phase of the same agreement, entered only if the concept is approved. Buys the measured plan set and the firm number that only measured plans can produce.	Design fee, a share of construction
Bid presented	Plan and price together, in person, decision asked for in the room.	Nothing new
Contract signed	Capped by statute at the lesser of a fixed sum or a tenth of the contract. Long-lead material is ordered the moment this lands, and that ordering window usually sets the earliest honest start rather than crew availability.	Deposit, at the statutory cap
During the build	One payment per completed phase: site preparation and grading, hardscape, irrigation, planting. Each falls due when the client can walk out and look at it.	Phase payments
Mid-build changes	Priced and signed before the work happens, never after. Nothing reaches a bill without one.	Change orders, as they arise
Punch list cleared	Ten business days from the walkthrough. The job is complete when the list is, which is where the incentive belongs.	Final payment
Then, if they take it	Maintenance, at a set price per visit, under its own agreement, month to month.	Recurring

Three things never to do with money

- **Never collect a deposit above the statutory cap.** It is the law, and a contractor asking for more is telling the client something.
- **Never take payment for a phase that is not visibly done.** The schedule follows the work, not the calendar.
- **Never do extra work on a verbal yes.** That is not generosity, it is a bill the client has not seen and will dispute.

Nothing is credited

Not the consultation, not the concept phase, not the design fee. Each is its own piece of work with its own price, and each is spent whether or not the next step happens. If any of them were credited, the construction price would simply have to carry those hours somewhere the client could not see them.

Say this on the first call. Plenty of clients assume otherwise, and signing is the worst possible moment for them to find out.

05 PROCEDURES · THE FRONT DOOR

Taking the call

SOP 01 Logging an inquiry

TRIGGER	OWNER	OUTPUT
Any inbound contact, any channel	Whoever takes it	One logged lead with a callback date
1. Record it in the WhatsApp admin log on arrival, not at the end of the day. Name, town, what they want, channel it came in on, date. 2. If it came by text, WhatsApp or a web form, log it and then call. A written enquiry answered in writing takes four days to qualify; the same enquiry answered by phone takes fifteen minutes. 3. Put one name against the lead and keep it there. That person is the client's point of contact from here to handover. The office prices the work, drafts the agreement and sends the paperwork; the point of contact stays the voice the client knows. 4. Give an actual callback date, not "someone will be in touch." 5. Send a short cover note ahead of the call or the visit: who is coming, what happens in the hour, and what to have ready. It costs a minute and it changes the tone of the visit.		

NEVER Leave a lead in a personal phone, a personal inbox or a memory. A lead that exists in one place only is a lead that dies when that person is on site.

SOP 02 The qualification call

TRIGGER	OWNER	OUTPUT
A logged inquiry	Owner or office admin	A booked visit, a routed lead, or a decline

Fifteen minutes. Five questions, in this order, because the last one is the gate and it lands better once they have described the problem out loud.

1. **What do you want done?** Ask for the problem, not the solution: standing water, dead lawn, no privacy, unusable slope, nowhere to sit. Never invite a client to specify the work; walking them back later costs more than the conversation you skipped.
2. **Where is the property?** Town first. It settles service area, route fit and whether a travel charge applies.
3. **When would you like it done?** Ask what the date is attached to: an event, a house sale, a permit clock, a school year, family arriving. A hard date changes what can honestly be promised and sometimes changes the answer.
4. **Who else is part of the decision?** Partner, family, HOA board, property manager. Ask whether they will be at the visit, and get them there if you can.
5. **What range are you planning around?** Asked plainly. Frame it as being for their benefit, which it is: it is how they find out now rather than after a design is underway.
6. **What made you decide to do this now?** The one that tells you most. "Family comes over and there is nowhere to sit," or "we saw something on your site and want it," changes what to propose more than any measurement does, and it is what the design has to answer to.

Ask for three things before hanging up, because they decide whether a visit is even needed: **photos of the area**, a rough sense of the **site layout**, and whether a **machine can reach the work** or it is all hand carry. Then sort the lead using Diagram 2, and take the visit fee on this call if a visit is what follows.

NEVER Give a number on this call. Not a range, not a ballpark, not a starting-at figure. A price from somebody who has not seen the property becomes the figure the client remembers for the rest of the project, and every later and better number then reads as an increase.

Record these three, every call, whatever the outcome

Lead source, the stated budget band or that it was refused, and the outcome. Ninety days of that is the only thing that will ever tell GMZ whether the fees filter the right people. No published research substitutes for it, and it costs about an hour a week.

06 PROCEDURES · THE VISIT

The site consultation

SOP 03 Running the consultation

TRIGGER	OWNER	OUTPUT
Fee taken, date agreed	Owner or office admin, alone	A filled checklist and either an offer or a decline

1. Confirm the fee is paid before travelling. If it is not, the visit is not booked.
2. Walk the property with the client. Access, grade, drainage, what is growing, the narrowest gate, where water sits after rain.
3. Ask the direct questions: scope, timing, what they are planning to spend. This is a working conversation, not a sales call.
4. Say what you think out loud, including what is not possible or not advisable. That candour is what the fee bought.
5. Run the compliance checks below before leaving. They change the paperwork, not the price, and they are cheap now and expensive later.
6. Close one of two ways: offer the concept phase with the fee stated, or say plainly that GMZ is not the right contractor for this one.
7. Log hours and miles spent against the lead, same day.

NEVER Leave with the client believing a number was given. If the hour produced an impression of cost, name it as a rough impression and say the range comes out of the concept phase.

The five that must come back, or no firm number is possible

- 1 Client name and the property address
- 2 Which items are in scope, not their dimensions
- 3 Material tier on the big-ticket items, or two tiers to price
- 4 Access: what a truck and a small machine can reach, and the narrowest gate
- 5 Demolition and disposal: in, out, or the client is handling it

Also state whether the site was measured or estimated by eye. A guess recorded as a measurement is the expensive kind of error.

Three compliance gates, checked on site

- **Any signer aged 65 or over.** The cancellation right is five days rather than three, and it goes on every agreement in the job, not only the first.
- **New landscape at or above 500 sq ft, or rehab at or above 2,500 sq ft, with a permit.** The state water ordinance documentation package is triggered. A licensed landscape contractor may sign that plan set, which is part of why the paid design step is defensible.
- **A rebate in play.** Nothing is torn out before the notice to proceed arrives. Check the water supplier and the turf area first.

Town rules differ. Name the page or the person you checked with.

Ask for these before the visit, on the qualification call

None of it is required, and it is the difference between one visit and two.

- Photos of the whole area from several angles, including the parts they are unhappy with.
- A plot plan or survey, any architect's or designer's drawings, and the HOA rules that apply.
- How a truck and a small machine would reach the work area, and the narrowest gate width.
- Whether water collects anywhere after rain.
- What they want kept, and what is already decided as against what is still open.

07 PROCEDURES · THE PAID DESIGN STEPS

Concept, then measured drawings

SOP 04 Concept and planning budget

TRIGGER	OWNER	OUTPUT
Client accepts the concept phase	Owner, with design support	Written concept plus an acknowledged planning range
1. Open the design agreement. This is its first phase, not a separate document. 2. Produce the written concept: what could happen on the property, from somebody who stood on it. 3. Produce the planning range, broken out by area of the property, not as one number. 4. Title it so it cannot be mistaken for a bid, and state on its face that it is a planning range. 5. List everything priced, then everything not priced, item by item. The second list is the one to walk through slowly. 6. Say how the plant warranty works, now rather than at handover. Plants are not guaranteed once their care is somebody else's, and they are where GMZ holds the maintenance account. A fair deal and a poor surprise, so it belongs here. 7. Get the acknowledgement. It confirms three things: they have seen the scope, they understand this is a range, and they want to continue. It obligates them to nothing further.		

NEVER Hand over a concept or a range without the acknowledgement. The whole point is that two people cannot remember the scope differently three months later.

SOP 05 Design development

TRIGGER	OWNER	OUTPUT
Concept approved and phase two entered	Owner, with design support	Measured plan set and a firm construction number
1. Measure the property. The clock to the presentation date starts here, not at signing, and the agreement should say so. 2. Draw to scale: layout of paving, walls, steps and beds; planting plan; irrigation and drainage resolved; materials specified closely enough to price and build from. 3. Set a target presentation date for this project, written into the agreement. If it needs to move, the client hears it before it passes rather than after. 4. Two rounds of revision are included. Log which round you are on. 5. File the working set, not only the exported drawing. Most clients come back for a second area, and a reusable plan turns that into an amendment rather than a fresh survey. 6. Know the difference and name it out loud: moving a patio, changing a plant palette or reworking a bed line is a revision. Adding an area of the property, or changing what the project is, is new scope and moves both the design and the construction number. 7. Anything past two rounds is priced in writing before it starts.		

PENDING The ownership and copyright position on drawings is not settled, and neither is whether a client may take paid-for drawings to another contractor. Until both are, do not answer either question on the spot. Say it is being finalised and refer it up.

Revision, or new scope? The distinction that keeps a design fee honest

Two rounds of revision are included. New scope is not a revision, and calling it one is how a design phase quietly runs to four times its fee. Say which it is at the time, out loud.

REVISION, INCLUDED	NEW SCOPE, REPRICED
Moving the patio, or changing its shape	Adding a second patio
Changing the plant palette	Adding an area of the property that was not in scope
Reworking a bed line	Adding lighting, or irrigation, that was not in the concept
Swapping one paving material for another	Changing what the project is

New scope moves both the design fee and the construction number, and both get restated in writing before the work continues.

08 PROCEDURES · ASKING FOR THE JOB

Presenting the bid, then signing it

SOP 06 Bid presentation

TRIGGER	OWNER	OUTPUT
Plan set and firm number complete	Owner	A decision, asked for in the room

1. Present in person, with the plan and the price together. Never email the package and wait.
2. Have every decision maker there. If they are not, reschedule rather than present twice.
3. Read the exclusions page out loud. It is the shortest page in the document and it is where nearly every contractor dispute actually lives.
4. Where the client asked to compare material levels, present alternates priced on the identical scope so the comparison is honest.
5. State the validity date on the face of the bid, and say what happens after it: material prices get re-checked and the changed line gets shown.
6. Ask for the decision before leaving.

NEVER Pad a number to cover something that might not happen. Name it as an exclusion instead. A padded bid charges every client for the unlucky ones and hides how much of their price was real work.

SOP 07 Contract, deposit and the cancellation window

TRIGGER	OWNER	OUTPUT
Client accepts the bid	Owner or office admin	Signed contract, deposit taken, start date held

1. Use the compliant contract template on every job above the statutory threshold. Every time, including for a client you have known for years.
2. Take the deposit at the statutory cap and not a dollar above it.
3. Write the payment schedule as one payment per completed phase, typically site preparation and grading, then hardscape, then irrigation, then planting, with the final payment tied to the cleared punch list.
4. Attach the cancellation notice. Three business days, or five where any signer is 65 or over. Without the correct notice attached the right to cancel does not expire at all.
5. Order long-lead material the moment the contract lands: specimen trees, stone from a particular quarry, custom metal. That window, rather than crew availability, usually sets the earliest honest start.
6. Only now put a start date in the calendar. A date is held by a signed contract, not by a conversation, and the client should be told that plainly rather than discover it in week six.

PENDING The compliant contract template and the written workmanship warranty do not exist yet. Until they do, this procedure cannot be followed as written, which makes both the most urgent documents on the outstanding list.

09 PROCEDURES · ON SITE

Starting the job, and running it

SOP 08 Pre-construction meeting

TRIGGER	OWNER	OUTPUT
Start date confirmed, before the first truck	Owner or supervisor	Agreed access, a named contact, no surprises on day one
1. Half an hour on site. Access route, gate codes, working hours, parking, pets, children, and where the crew may and may not walk. 2. Give them one name and number to call, and say who it is not. 3. Walk them through what week one actually looks like, including the noisy and ugly parts. Demolition looks like a disaster to somebody who was not expecting it. 4. Call the utility locate in. It is free, required, and the marks have to be on the ground before a shovel goes in, so it goes in ahead of day one rather than that morning. 5. Re-measure the gate against what the plan assumed. This is the cheapest half hour in the whole job.		

SOP 09 Running the build

TRIGGER	OWNER	OUTPUT
Work starts	Supervisor, reporting to owner	Phases completed and paid, no unbilled surprises
1. Work in the contracted phase order. Anything that runs under paving, and all grading and drainage, goes first so the property is not built twice. 2. Send one written update a week, the same day each week, with a photo: what changed, what is next, what needs a decision from them. 3. Report progress to the office in the same shape every time, because that is what an invoice gets built from: which phase, what is finished in it, what is outstanding, any change orders signed, and whether the finish date has moved. The office raises the invoice from that; nobody in the field raises one. 4. Raise a payment only when its phase is visibly complete and the client could walk out and see it. 5. Anything outside the contracted scope stops and becomes a signed change order before it happens. No exceptions, including for things that take ten minutes. 6. Keep dated photographs of everything that gets covered up. Base depth, drainage runs, sleeves, footings. Half of licensing complaints close for insufficient evidence, and whoever holds the paperwork holds the advantage.		

NEVER Let a crew member agree to extra work. Quoting is not a laborer responsibility. The correct answer on site is always "I will have the office price that for you," and then it goes to the office the same day.

The weekly update, as a template

Same day each week, four lines and a photo. It takes five minutes and it is the single cheapest thing GMZ does to keep a client calm through the ugly middle of a build.

What changed this week	Plainly, including anything that did not go to plan.
What happens next week	So nobody is surprised by a machine arriving.
What we need from you	Any decision, with the date it is needed by. If nothing, say nothing is needed.
Where we are against the finish date	On, ahead, or behind and by how much. Behind is fine; silence is not.
One photo	Even if the week was all excavation and it looks like nothing.

10 DIAGRAM 4 AND SOP 09B

When something changes mid-build

Three causes, and two of them are avoidable at bid time. Scope the client adds, decisions made late, and genuine unknowns underground. All three run the same procedure.

1

Stop that part of the work

Not the whole job, just the affected area. Carrying on is what turns a \$400 conversation into a \$4,000 argument.

2

Photograph it, dated, before anything is disturbed

Old slab or footing, rock, abandoned irrigation, septic remnant, roots at a size an arborist should see, a drain that goes nowhere, utilities not where any map says.

3

Show the client, on site if possible

They should learn about this standing next to it, never from the final invoice.

4

Price it at the office and check it against the minimum

A change order is a small job and gets the same floor check as a large one. Extra days, extra material, extra dump passes, extra access difficulty.

5

Get it signed by both parties before the work happens

A written amendment to the contract. Nothing is added to a bill without one.

6

Resume, and note the schedule effect in that week's update

If it moves the finish date, say so the same week rather than letting the client work it out.

How to keep the count near zero

- Get materials chosen before work starts, not during.
- Walk the exclusions page at bid time and invite the client to challenge it.
- Assess the drainage rather than assuming the existing setup is fine.
- Ask for the while-you're-here list before the contract, not in week two. Adding at bid time is nearly always cheaper than adding after the crew has moved past that part of the yard.
- Where there is real doubt about what is under a surface, say so at bid time and offer a test hole. It costs a fraction of the same discovery in week two with a crew standing on it.

The sentence that costs the most money

"No problem, we can do that."

Said on site, about something outside scope, without paper. It is not generosity. It is a bill the client has not seen yet, and it will be argued about at the exact moment GMZ is asking for the final payment.

What actually turns up under a Peninsula yard

None of it is visible from the surface, which is precisely why it sits on the exclusions page instead of inside the price: an old slab or footing under the lawn, rock, an abandoned irrigation line, a septic remnant, tree roots at a size where an arborist ought to look at them, a drain that goes nowhere, and utility lines that are not where any map says they are.

If GMZ padded every bid for things that are usually not there, every client would be paying for the unlucky ones.

11 PROCEDURES · FINISHING

Handing the garden over

SOP 10 Substantial completion and the punch list

TRIGGER	OWNER	OUTPUT
Work substantially finished	Owner or supervisor, with the client	A written punch list, both parties holding a copy

1. Walk the finished project with the client before calling it done. Every job, no exceptions.
2. Write down everything that is not right: a paver sitting proud, a head spraying the fence, a plant that went in leaning. Their list, not an edited version of it.
3. Both parties keep a copy, dated and signed.
4. Clear the list within ten business days.
5. The job is complete when the list is, not before, and the final payment is tied to that moment.

SAY THIS OUT LOUD Some things only show up once somebody lives with the work. The punch list is a tool, not a cutoff for talking to us. Clients who hear that call instead of posting a review.

SOP 11 Closeout package

TRIGGER	OWNER	OUTPUT
Punch list cleared	Office admin	A handed-over package and a maintenance offer

1. Hand over a copy of the completed line items with a suggested care interval against each one. That single sheet is what makes the maintenance proposal obvious rather than a pitch: the client can see what was installed and how often each part of it wants attention.
2. Hand over: a copy of the plan, the plant list, the irrigation zone map with the programmed settings, a care guide, and the written warranty.
3. Walk whoever will care for the garden through the irrigation controller, including if that is the client's own gardener.
4. Make the maintenance offer with a real cadence and a real price, not a vague pitch. Say plainly that it is an offer and not a condition, and that the project price does not depend on the answer.
5. Take the final payment.

PENDING The closeout package template does not exist. Three published answers on the website already promise its contents, so either the template gets written or the promise has to come out of all three answers together.

SOP 12 Follow-up calls

TRIGGER	OWNER	OUTPUT
30 days, then 6 months from completion	Office admin	Problems caught early, referrals, maintenance conversions

1. Diary both calls at closeout, not later.
2. Ask specifically about the establishment year: watering, anything that has failed, anything they have questions about.
3. Ask for a referral only if the call goes well, and ask in writing for permission before quoting anyone publicly.

This is the cheapest referral and maintenance conversion available anywhere in this manual, and it is two phone calls.

12 PROCEDURES · MAINTENANCE

Taking on an account

SOP M1 Maintenance inquiry

TRIGGER	OWNER	OUTPUT
Referral, build handover or search	Whoever takes it	Logged in the same place as build leads

1. Same log as everything else. Maintenance leads dying in a separate inbox is how a route stops growing.
2. Get the town and the property type before anything else.

SOP M2 Route-fit screen

TRIGGER	OWNER	OUTPUT
Before any quote or visit	Office admin	A route day, or an honest no

1. Check the address against the existing route days. Openings are specific days, not any day.
2. If it sits near existing stops, name the day on the call.
3. If it does not, say so. An off-route stop costs far more than the extra miles suggest, and the cost is drive time between stops.
4. Clustering is the only real lever on this book, and it compounds across every account. A screen at intake costs nothing and stops the problem getting worse.

NEVER Quote a maintenance account before the route check. Taking an account GMZ would chronically reach late serves nobody, and it is far easier to decline now than to resign later.

SOP M3 Property walk and quote

TRIGGER	OWNER	OUTPUT
Route fit confirmed, walk fee taken	Owner or office admin	One set price per visit and a cadence

1. Walk it. How much lawn, how much planted bed, a year of pruning, how much green waste comes off it, how easily equipment moves around it.
2. Decide the cadence honestly against the growing season, not the winter. A lawn on a two-week cycle in late spring stops being maintained and starts being caught up.
3. If the property needs catch-up work first, quote that separately as a service call. A reset is not a maintenance visit.
4. Produce one set price per visit that does not move week to week because one visit ran long.
5. Name what sits outside it: work that is not routine care, and materials brought for the client.

Choosing the cadence

- **Weekly** where there is lawn, a lot of planted bed, or a client who wants the place tidy every day of the week.
- **Every other week** for established shrubs, groundcover, gravel and decomposed granite.

Changing cadence changes the agreement and the price, so it is confirmed in writing rather than by quietly showing up more often.

The catch-up trap

A neglected property quoted at its steady-state price loses money for months while the crew digs it out. Quote the reset as a separate service call, get it done, and start the agreement on a property that is actually at the condition the price assumes.

13 PROCEDURES · MAINTENANCE

Running an account, and renewing it

SOP M4 Service agreement

TRIGGER	OWNER	OUTPUT
Price and cadence agreed	Office admin	A signed agreement with its terms on its face

1. Write on the face of it: visit scope, cadence, service day, price, what is in, what is out, the notice period, and the annual review month.
2. Month to month, thirty days' notice either side, no term to buy out.
3. A recurring visit is neither an emergency nor short notice, so assume the standard cancellation regime applies and attach the notice.
4. Keep it separate from any construction contract; neither absorbs the other.

SOP M5 Onboarding visit

TRIGGER	OWNER	OUTPUT
Agreement signed, first visit	Supervisor	The baseline record for the account

1. Treat the first visit as an assessment, not a normal stop.
2. Photograph the whole property, dated.
3. Walk the irrigation zone by zone and record what works and what does not.
4. Assess the built parts as a liability, not only as scope: irrigation, patios, steps, walls, lighting, drainage. Anything already failing becomes GMZ's problem the day the account starts, so write it down and price it first.
5. Note anything already broken, in writing. This is the record every later argument gets measured against, including "it was fine before you started." Quote repairs found as a separate service call rather than absorbing them.

SOP M6 Route operations

TRIGGER	OWNER	OUTPUT
Every service day	Supervisor	Consistent visits at the agreed price

1. Fixed day, same crew where possible. A property serviced by whoever is free that morning gets maintained to the average of everyone who has been there.
2. Work from the standing list for that property rather than whatever catches the eye.
3. Price does not move because one visit ran long. That is what a set price means.
4. Anything outside routine care stops and gets priced and approved first, same as a change order on a build. Rain: reschedule rather than skip where the route allows, and say which it is.

SOP M7 Annual review

TRIGGER	OWNER	OUTPUT
One fixed month a year, every account	Owner	Scope confirmed, price re-struck, agreement renewed

1. Run every account through it in one month; a concentrated week beats twelve scattered conversations.
2. Ask whether the scope is still right. Gardens grow; a property that took an hour three years ago does not now.
3. Set the year's goals in the client's terms: more bloom across more of the season, trees established, fruit setting. Then say what that takes, usually a visit count and sometimes more management presence than the account buys today.
4. Re-strike the price. A price that never changes on paper changes somewhere else instead, usually in how much time the property actually gets.
5. Align renewals with the calendar year: the wage floor rises every January on a published schedule.

PENDING The review month is not picked. Choose a quiet one: it becomes the single moment a price change reaches every account.

14 PROCEDURES · SMALL WORK

Service calls, and who may go alone

SOP S1 One-off service call

TRIGGER	OWNER	OUTPUT
Work too small to mobilise a build crew	Office admin books it; see the tiers below for who attends	The thing fixed, and an offer of the maintenance book

1. Decide the tier from the work, using the table below. This decides who goes and what the minimum is.
2. **Most of this work does not need a visit to quote.** Pressure washing, mulching, compost, a green-waste clearance and similar are priced off area or volume, so photos and a rough measurement over the phone are enough. Quote it, take it, book it. Keep the process light: these are the jobs that pay for themselves in goodwill, and a site visit to price an afternoon of mulching costs more than the job earns.
3. Quote the minimum on the call and take it before booking.
4. Tell the client which tier their job is and why. "That one needs two people and a truck" is a perfectly good sentence.
5. Encourage them to bundle. One trip covering five small things is far better value than five trips covering one each, and it is better for GMZ too.
6. If the work turns out to be recurring, offer the maintenance book, which is usually cheaper for the same work repeated.

NEVER Send a truck team on a job the one-person tier covers. It costs GMZ a build slot and the client the higher minimum, and the client will find that out.

Quote these over the phone. No visit.

- **Pressure washing.** Priced by area. Ask for photos and rough dimensions.
- **Mulch and compost.** Priced by volume and how far it has to be carried.
- **Green-waste clearance and one-time tidy-ups.** Priced off photos.
- **A named repair the client can photograph.** A broken head, a valve, a controller.

The photos do the work a visit would. If they arrive and the job is materially different from what was described, say so before starting and requote rather than absorbing it.

These still need eyes on the property first

- Anything where access is the unknown: a narrow gate, a slope, a long carry, stairs.
- Drainage complaints. Water is never where the client thinks it is.
- Tree work of any size, which is an arborist question before it is a price.
- Anything the client describes as "while you're here, can you also..."

When it needs a visit, that is a consultation and it carries the consultation fee, not the service call minimum.

A phone-quoted job, end to end

Mulching a front bed, which is the commonest version of this. Fifteen minutes of office time and no visit.

- 1 Client calls. Ask for photos of the bed and a rough length and width, and whether a wheelbarrow can get to it from where a truck can park.
- 2 Work the volume off the area and the depth. Add the carry if the barrow route is long or goes up steps.
- 3 Quote against the correct tier minimum, say which tier it is and why, and take payment.
- 4 Book it onto a day that suits the route rather than a day that suits the calendar.
- 5 On arrival, check the job against the photos before starting. If it is materially bigger, stop and requote.
- 6 Before leaving, ask what else has been bothering them, and offer the maintenance book if the property clearly wants regular attention.

15 PROCEDURES · SMALL WORK

Who goes, and what it costs

TIER	WHO ATTENDS	SUITABLE WORK	CONSUMES BUILD CAPACITY
One person administrative	An administrative role, alone. Never a laborer.	Diagnose a fault; program or swap a controller; replace a head or a valve; light hand pruning; clear a small blockage; take measurements.	No. Draws on nobody who is on a truck, so it does not touch the build calendar.
Two people crew and truck	A truck team	Anything involving weight one person should not lift alone; a powered machine; work above standing height; tree limbs; hauling material away.	Yes. Schedule it against build work, not on top of it.

Why a laborer does not run one of these

Not a question of competence. A solo visit involves quoting work, taking payment and representing GMZ on somebody's property with nobody else there. Those are management responsibilities, and putting them on a laborer role is unfair to the person and creates exposure for the company.

Do not floor-check a one-person visit against crew minimums

The minimums assume field labour and divide by crew time. A one-person administrative visit uses neither, so running it through that check reports a large shortfall on a job that is perfectly sound, and the tool will refuse the arithmetic outright. Price these on what the visit is worth and on what the hour would otherwise have earned.

Turning a service call into an account, which is where the value is

A one-off visit is worth having. A one-off visit that becomes a standing account is worth many times more, and the moment to say so is while standing on the property having just fixed something.

- **Ask what else has been bothering them.** Most people booked one thing and have been living with four. Bundling them onto this visit is better value for them and a better hour for GMZ.
- **If the property needs regular attention, say so plainly and quote it.** Not a vague pitch: a cadence, a service day, and a price per visit.
- **Check the route first.** An account that does not fit a route day should not be offered, however much the client wants it. Run SOP M2 before making the offer, not after.
- **If they decline, leave it.** One offer, made well, then the work speaks. Pressure on somebody's own doorstep is how a good service call becomes a bad review.

When the job is bigger than the photos showed

Quoting without a visit buys speed and accepts this risk, so it needs a rule rather than a judgement call on somebody's driveway. Say it before starting, not after.

- **Stop before you start.** Ten minutes of work done is ten minutes of argument about who owes what.
- **Photograph what is actually there,** then call the office. The office requotes; the person on site does not.
- **Offer the client both options plainly:** the new price, or do the part that was quoted and leave the rest. Either is fine and both are better than absorbing it.
- **If it is marginally bigger, do it and say so.** Goodwill on a small job is worth more than the twenty minutes, and this is the tier where that trade makes sense.

Log it either way. A pattern of underquoted photo jobs means the questions on the call need changing, not the crew.

16 PROCEDURES · WHEN IT GOES WRONG

An unhappy client, and an unpaid invoice

Neither of these is rare, and both get handled worse when they are handled for the first time. The cost of each is decided in the first forty-eight hours.

SOP X1 A client who is not happy

TRIGGER	OWNER	OUTPUT
A complaint that is not a punch-list defect or a change order	The point of contact, escalating to the owner	An outcome the client accepts, in writing, in the job file
1. Take the call yourself, the same day. Not whoever is free. The person the client has dealt with all along is the person who has to hear this. 2. Let them finish. Complaints run longer than the problem and the part that actually matters usually arrives last, after the part they rehearsed. 3. Sort it into one of three before promising anything. A defect, which is the punch list. A scope misunderstanding, which is the contract and the exclusions page. Or a disappointment, where the work is as specified and not as imagined. They resolve differently, and treating one as another is what turns a single complaint into three. 4. If it is physical, go and look within a day or two. A photo is somebody's interpretation, and turning up matters more to most people than being right does. 5. Put what happens next in writing the same day, with a date on it. "I need to look into this and I will call you Thursday" is a fine answer. Going quiet is not. 6. Where GMZ is wrong, fix it and do not negotiate. Where GMZ is not, show the clause and then offer a price to do it anyway; the second half of that sentence is what keeps the relationship. 7. Escalate to the owner <i>before</i> any refund, any significant goodwill work, or any conversation that mentions the licensing board. Not afterwards. 8. Record it and the outcome. The same complaint arriving twice is a process problem, not a difficult client.		

NEVER Argue on site in front of the crew, and never say "that is not what you signed." Roughly half of licensing complaints close for insufficient evidence, and the party holding dated notes, photographs and written commitments is the party that does well out of that.

SOP X2 An invoice that has not been paid

TRIGGER	OWNER	OUTPUT
A payment past its due date	Office admin, escalating to the owner	Paid, or a decision that is recorded and supportable
1. Day one. Check it was sent, to the right person, at the right address. Most late invoices are unsent, misaddressed, or sitting with a partner who never saw them. 2. Day three, a call rather than an email. Ask whether anything about the work is the reason. An unpaid invoice is often an unspoken complaint, and if it is, stop and run X1 instead: chasing money through a grievance never works. 3. Day seven, in writing. Restate what the payment is for, which phase it covers, and when it was due. 4. Day fourteen, the owner calls. If the problem is cash rather than dissatisfaction, offer a schedule and put whatever is agreed in writing. 5. Do not start the next phase on an unpaid one. That is what the phase schedule is for: exposure never runs past a single phase unless somebody lets it. 6. Before stopping work, say so in writing, with a date and what it means for their schedule. Never simply fail to arrive. 7. Past thirty days with no arrangement, it is the owner's decision and nobody else's: pursue it, settle it, or write it off. Whoever is doing the chasing should not be the one making that call.		

PENDING California's lien deadlines are short and statutory, and the preliminary notice in particular is served near the start of a job rather than when a problem appears. If GMZ is not serving one routinely, that remedy may already be gone by the time an invoice is late. Confirm the current windows with counsel and build the notice into the contract template rather than into this procedure.

17 PROCEDURES · GOVERNANCE

Two rules that protect every number and every promise

SOP G1 Before any number reaches a client

TRIGGER	OWNER	OUTPUT
Any quote, change order or re-struck price	Owner	A number that covers labour, overhead and profit

1. Take the quantities off the plan first, so the arithmetic does not depend on anyone's afternoon.
2. Audit the gaps out loud before pricing. Universal on every job: delivery, rental days, dump passes, access surcharges for long carry, slope or a narrow gate, transit, permits. A gap found now is a conversation; found later it is GMZ's money.
3. Never bill owned equipment as a rental. It is already recovered in the burden, and adding it inflates the cost basis and raises the minimum against yourself.
4. Check against the minimum for the correct service line. Route work is maintenance, and the maintenance minimum is the higher of the two, so using the default silently under-prices it.
5. Read the labour-adjusted verdict, not the headline one, on any job carrying real material. A heavy-material job can clear the headline number with the labour priced at nothing.
6. If it lands under, there are three ways out and only three: **add days, cut scope, or hold the price and walk away.** Quietly quoting under it is not one of them.

NEVER Thin base depth, drainage or soil preparation to hit a number. It makes the job cheaper on paper and dearer in a few years, and the client pays that second bill while GMZ's name is on the work.

SOP G2 Before anything is published

TRIGGER	OWNER	OUTPUT
Any change to the website or a client-facing document	Owner	Nothing published that nobody has decided

1. An undecided policy stays unpublished. A warranty term, a lead time or a fee nobody has agreed to is worse than silence: it is a promise made by accident, and a client will hold GMZ to whatever the website said.
2. A client quote stays unpublished until that client has agreed in writing to be quoted publicly.
3. A project location is a town, never a street address.
4. No internal figure goes on a client-facing document: no cost, no margin, no overhead, no rate, no minimum.
5. Never publish a starting-at figure. It is a number attached to nothing and it is the first thing quoted back at you.
6. Change a fact in its one home, then let everything else read from there. Never retype it into a second place.

KIND OF FACT	ITS ONE HOME
Minimums, rates, crew, route days, vehicles, drivers	The facts sheet
What may be said to a client	Published website answers only
Phone, address, licence number, tagline	Site data, once
The stage model and why the money is shaped this way	The pipeline and pricing document
What to actually do at each stage	This manual

18 WHAT IS NOT SETTLED

Seven open items, and what each one blocks

Each of these stops a procedure in this manual from being followed as written. Ordered by what it costs to leave alone.

OPEN ITEM	BLOCKS	NEEDS	WHAT IT COSTS TO LEAVE
A first-year package for new installations	SOP 04, 11	A decision, then the warranty	Asked for: a new garden should be sold a defined first year of care rather than a month-to-month route slot. It pairs with the plant guarantee, which already depends on GMZ holding the maintenance account. It cannot publish yet, because it needs the warranty written and it contradicts the live answer that says there is no term to buy out.
Compliant construction contract template	SOP 07	A lawyer	Every job above the threshold is currently signed on something that has not been checked. This is the item with the worst downside if left.
Written workmanship warranty	SOP 07, 11	A decision, then half a page	Callbacks get negotiated from zero, out of the current job's margin, with nothing excluded and nothing defined.
Drawings: who owns them, what GMZ retains	SOP 05	A lawyer	The question arrives exactly as the client hands over the design fee, and the honest answer today is that it is being finalised.
Whether drawings may go to another contractor	SOP 05	A lawyer	Must match the ownership clause. Answering these two separately is how they end up contradicting each other.
Closeout package template	SOP 11	A template, then reuse	Three published answers already promise its contents. Either it gets written or the promise comes out of all three.
The annual review month	SOP M7	A decision	Prices on the maintenance book drift, because there is no moment at which they can all be re-struck.

The fee schedule, as it stands today

- **Design or build consultation.** \$175, first hour on the property, prepaid.
- **Maintenance property walk.** \$75, prepaid.
- **Outside the towns served.** \$100 travel on top, and no further than about forty miles.
- **Concept phase.** Its own fee, stated in writing before it starts.
- **Design development.** Ten to fifteen percent of the construction price.
- **Deposit.** The statutory cap: the lesser of a thousand dollars or a tenth of the contract.
- **Service calls.** \$200 for the one-person tier, \$395 where the work needs a truck team.

None of these are credited against anything later.

The one thing to measure this quarter

Ninety days of logged leads: source, stated band, whether a visit was booked, and the outcome. GMZ now charges at the top of both funnels while carrying open route days and freed project capacity. A fee at the door filters hardest exactly when there is capacity to spare, which is the situation today.

Whether that trade is worth it is answerable, but only from GMZ's own numbers. No published source can settle it, and an hour a week for a quarter will.

19 HOW TO RUN THE SESSION

Sixty minutes, three decisions, one thing to measure

Do not present the manual. Nobody sits through twenty-one procedures. Present the three decisions it needs, use the diagrams as the visual argument, and leave the procedures as the pre-read that proves the decisions are grounded.

0:00	Where we were	One slide, honestly. Leads arriving in three inboxes, no qualification before the drive, a concept and a budget given away free, contracts varying job to job, no punch list, no follow-up. No decision asked. This is the baseline the rest is measured against.
0:05	The shape now	Diagram 1, the whole business on one page. Two lines, one front door, sorted once on the first call. Then Diagram 2, the routing tree, because that is the single change that stops a build crew doing an hour of work. No decision. Establish that the business has a shape.
0:15	Where the money comes in	Diagram 3. Walk the timeline once, then land the two points that matter: precision is earned in stages, and nothing is credited so every cost is visible on its own. DECISION 1 Ratify the fee schedule now live: \$175, \$75, \$100 travel, a forty-mile limit.
0:25	The small-work tier	Present the two tiers and the reason a laborer does not run a solo visit, since that is the part that will get questioned. No decision: the minimums are set and the fee schedule is complete.
0:32	The four documents that do not exist	Contract template, warranty, closeout package, and the two drawings questions. Three of them need a lawyer's time. Be blunt that SOP 07 cannot be followed as written until the contract exists, which means every job above the threshold is signed on something unchecked. DECISION 2 Authorise the legal spend and name a date.
0:42	The honest risk	GMZ now charges at the top of both funnels while carrying open route days and capacity freed when an account closed. A fee at the door filters hardest exactly when there is capacity to spare. Say this before anyone else notices it. DECISION 3 Approve the ninety-day lead log, and agree to revisit the consultation fee on that data rather than on opinion.
0:52	What happens next week	The annual review month, the production host and go-live date, and who owns the lead log. Small items, but they are what turns a decision into a change.
0:58	Close	Restate the three decisions taken and who is doing what by when. Nothing else.

Send as the pre-read, three days ahead

- This manual, whole. Ask them to read pages 3 to 5, the diagrams, and the open register on 19.
- *Lead-to-sale pipeline and pricing*, which carries the reasoning behind the fees if anyone wants to argue about them.
- One line naming the three decisions, so nobody arrives expecting a status update.

Three questions to have an answer ready for

- **"Won't charging for the visit lose us work?"** Yes, some. That is the point, and it is also the risk. Hence the lead log.
- **"Why isn't the design fee credited?"** Because the hours are spent whether or not the client builds, and crediting them means burying them in a construction price nobody can see.
- **"Can't we skip the lawyer?"** The deposit cap, the required notices and the cancellation windows are statutory. A contract missing its notice can be cancelled indefinitely.